

Disaster scams & false aid offers

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QUICK ANSWER / START HERE

Pause before paying, sharing identification or following an urgent aid message. Verify the organisation using a contact you find independently, ask for written terms and avoid pressure to pay immediately. Keep emergency funds for verified essentials. A logo, uniform or forwarded link does not establish trust.

Do now.

- ☐ **Find an independent contact**
01 Use the organisation's known website or an existing trusted number rather than the contact in an unsolicited message. Confirm the specific programme or provider.
- ☐ **Protect personal information**
02 Share only what the verified process needs. Never give account passwords, one-time codes or a full identity document to an unverified caller.
- ☐ **Check payment demands**
03 Unexpected upfront fees, gift cards, cryptocurrency or pressure to pay immediately are warning signs. Ask for written terms and time to review.
- ☐ **Check repair offers**
04 Verify relevant credentials, references and a written scope before hiring. Do not let a door-to-door offer rush you into unsafe entry or a large advance payment.
- ☐ **Preserve evidence safely**
05 Keep receipts and message details without engaging further. Use verified consumer-protection or legal support when safe and available.

Keep the plan moving.

IF HELP IS UNAVAILABLE

If reporting channels are unavailable, stop contact, protect remaining money and accounts, and retain the records for later. A promised refund is not a reason to make another payment.

Watch for.

An offer of transport or shelter may also carry exploitation risk. Do not surrender documents or separate from family because a stranger promises priority assistance.

People & practical needs.

Assign a trusted adult to each person who needs assistance. Keep medicines, essential contacts and a workable reunion plan with the group

Next decision.

Warn trusted people privately about confirmed scams without circulating sensitive victim information. If payment or credentials were compromised, contact the relevant bank or provider through a known channel.

YOUR SITUATION / PRIVATE WORKSHEET

TIME / LOCATION / CHANGING CONDITIONS

PEOPLE / ACCESS OR MEDICAL NEEDS

SOURCES / SCOPE / LIMITS

Source-linked civilian guidance, not independent clinical or specialist certification. U.S. references; emergency numbers and services differ. Training and product instructions remain essential.

FTC · Recovering from a weather emergency

Full guide: <https://ospreyzero.com/emergencies/disaster-scams/>